SantaLand Diaries

By David Sedaris

DAVID: **(Pgs 1-44)** I was in a coffee shop looking through the want ads when I read:

OFFICIAL VOICE: Macy's Herald Square, the largest store in the world, has big opportunities for outgoing, fun-loving people of all shapes and sizes who want more than just a holiday job! Working as an elf in Macy's SantaLand means being at the center of the excitement!

INTRODUCTION

PERKS TO BEING AN ELF: You can walk home with all the leftover toys come December 25th . . . a never-ending supply of cookies, milk, hot chocolate and other tasty holiday treats. THE DOWN SIDE: Elves are required to wait on Santa and Mrs. Claus hand and foot . . . Mall Duty: they receive the brunt of screaming kids, stray kicks to the shins and sticky candy cane hands in their hair. So even though Will Ferrell made being an ELF seem like the next best thing to Christmas . . . the reality of being a mall elf is, well . . . my therapist suggested that I should keep

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DAVID: This morning we were lectured by the Santa-Land managers and presented with a Xeroxed booklet of regulations titled "The Elfin Guide." In the afternoon we were given a tour of SantaLand, which really is something. It's beautiful, a real wonderland, with ten thousand sparkling lights, false snow, train sets, bridges, decorated trees, mechanical penguins and bears, and really tall candy canes.

We traveled the path a second time and were given the code names for various posts, such as "The Vomit Corner," a mirrored wall near the Magic Tree, where nauseous children tend to surrender the contents of their stomachs. When someone vomits, the nearest elf is supposed to yell "VAMOOSE," which is the name of the janitorial product used by the store. We were taken to the "Oh, My God, Corner," a position near the escalator. People arriving see the long line and say "Oh, my God!" and it is an elf's job to calm them down and explain that it will take no longer than an hour to see Santa.

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We were given a demonstration of the various positions in action, performed by returning elves who were so animated and relentlessly cheerful that it embarrassed me to walk past them. I don't know that I could look someone in the eye and exclaim, "Oh, my goodness, I think I see Santa!" or "Can you close your eyes and make a very special Christmas wish!" Everything these elves said had an exclamation point at the end of it!!! I am afraid I won't be able to provide the grinding enthusiasm Santa is asking for. I'll be a low-key sort of an elf.

My costume is green. I wear green velvet knickers, a yellow turtleneck, a forest-green velvet smock, and a perky stocking cap decorated with spangles. My elf name is Crumpet. We were allowed to choose our own names and given permission to change them according to our outlook on the snowy world.

Today was the official opening day of SantaLand and I worked as a Magic Window Elf. The Magic Window is located in the adult "Quick Peep" line. My job was to say, "Step on the Magic Star and look through the window, and you can see Santa!" I was at the Magic Window for 15 minutes before a man approached me

MAN: You look so stupid.

DAVID: He had a point. But, at least I get paid to look stupid; he gives it away for free. But I can't say things like that because I'm supposed to be merry. So instead I said, "Thank you!" as if I had misunderstood and thought he said, "You look terrific." *(to man)* Thank you!

[One day] I was stuck being Photo Elf with Santa Santa. I don't know his real name; no one does. During most days, there is a slow period when you sit around the house and talk to your Santa. Most of them are nice guys and we sit around and laugh, but Santa Santa takes himself a bit too seriously. I asked him where he lives, Brooklyn or Manhattan.

SANTA SANTA: Why, I live at the North Pole with Mrs. Claus! *(Santa laugh)*

DAVID: I asked what he does the rest of the year . . .

SANTA SANTA: *(Santa laugh)* I make toys for all of the children.

DAVID: *(to Santa)* Yes, but what do you do for money?

SANTA SANTA: Santa doesn't need money. (Santa laugh)

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DAVID: Santa Santa sits and waves and jingles his bell sash when no one is there. He actually recited "The Night Before Christmas," and it was just the two of us in the house, no children. Just us. What do you do with a nut like that?

SANTA SANTA: Oh, Little Elf, Little Elf, straighten up those mantel toys for Santa.

DAVID: I reminded him that I have a name, Crumpet, and then I straightened up the stuffed animals. *(beat)* Santa Santa has an elaborate little act for the children. He'll talk to them and give a hearty chuckle and ring his bells and then he asks them to name their favorite Christmas carol. Most of them say "Rudolph, the Red-Nosed Reindeer." Santa Santa then asks if they will sing it for him. The children are shy and don't want to sing out loud, so Santa Santa says

SANTA SANTA: Oh, Little Elf, Little Elf! Help young Brenda to sing that favorite carol of hers.

DAVID: Then I have to stand there and *(sings enthusiastically)* Rudolph, the Red-Nosed Reindeer. . *(drops elf façade)* which I hate. Half the time young Brenda's parents are my age and that certainly doesn't help!

[Another day] I worked as an Exit Elf, telling people *(in a loud voice)* THIS WAY OUT OF SANTALAND. A woman was standing at one of the cash registers paying for her idea of a picture, while her son lay beneath her having a tantrum.

RILEY: *(pitches a tremendous fit)*

WOMAN: Riley, if you don't start behaving yourself, Santa's not going to bring you any of those toys you asked for.

RILEY: He is too going to bring me toys, liar, he already told me!

WOMAN: *(grabbing David's arm)* You there, Elf, tell Riley here that if he doesn't start behaving immediately, then Santa's going to change his mind and bring him coal for Christmas.

DAVID: *(to audience)* I told her Santa no longer traffics in coal. Instead, if you're bad he comes to your house and steals things If he didn't behave himself, Santa was going to take away his TV and all his electrical appliances and leave him in the dark. *(to Riley)* All your appliances, including the refrigerator!

RILEY: *(pitches a tremendous fit)*

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DAVID: Your food is going to spoil and smell bad!

RILEY: *(continues his fit)*

DAVID: It's going to be so cold and dark where you are. Man, Riley, are you ever going to suffer! You're going to wish you never heard the name Santa!

RILEY: *(gasps for air, processes the new information and abruptly stops his fit)*

DAVID: Lately I am feeling trollish and have changed my elf name from Crumpet to Blisters. Blisters — I think it's cute.

I was the Pointer Elf this afternoon, one of my favorite jobs. The Pointer stands inside the Magic Tree and appoints available Santa Elves to lead parties of visitors to the houses. First-time visitors are enthusiastic, eager that they are moments away from Santa. Some of the others, having been here before, have decided to leave nothing to chance.

Out of all the Santas, two are black and both are so light-skinned that, with the beard and makeup, you would be hard-pressed to determine their race. Last week, a Black woman became upset when, having requested a "Santa of Color," she was sent to Jerome. I've had requests from both sides -- White Santa, Black Santa. A Pointer Elf is instructed to . . . *(shrugs shoulders, feigning ignorance)* There's only one Santa.

After she was led to the house, the woman demanded to speak with a manager.

WOMAN: *(complaining)* He's not black!

DAVID: Bridget assured this woman that Jerome was indeed black.

WOMAN: Well, he isn't black enough!

DAVID: We were packed today, absolutely packed, and everyone was cranky. Once the line gets long, we break it up into four different lines because anyone in their right mind would leave if they knew it would take over 2 hours to see Santa. 2 hours — you could see a movie in 2 hours. Standing in a 2-hour line makes people worry that they're not living in a democratic nation. People stand in line for 2 hours and they go over the edge. I was sent into the hallway to direct the second phase of the line. The hallway was packed with people, and all of them seemed to stop me with a question.

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MAN 1: Which way to the down escalator,

WOMAN 1: Which way to the elevator *(rapidly changing voices and personas)* the Patio Restaurant, gift wrap, the women's rest room, Trim-A-Tree.

DAVID: There was a line for Santa and a line for the women's bathroom, and one woman, after asking me a dozen questions already, asked

WOMAN: Which is the line for the women's bathroom?

DAVID: *(shouting)* The line with all the women in it!

WOMAN: I'm going to have you fired!

DAVID: I had two people say that to me today

MAN: I'm going to have you fired!

DAVID: Go ahead, be my guest. I'm wearing a green velvet costume; it doesn't get any worse than this. Who do these people think they are? *(sings the first verse)* You'd better watch out . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

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